Top of the World

- India is the first team to win the T20 World Cup after remaining undefeated in all its eight matches in the tournament
- Rohit Sharma with 257 runs and Arshdeep Singh with 17 wickets were India's top performers
- In 2024, India scored its highest T20 total, posting 297/6 against Bangladesh in Hyderabad in October, following it up with 283/1, its second highest, against South Africa in Johannesburg
- The last time India won the T20 World Cup was in 2007, under M.S. Dhoni's captaincy. They beat Pakistan by five runs in the final in Johannesburg

attack led by the incomparable Jasprit Bumrah and a fluid batting order that visited ultraviolence upon hapless opposition bowlers.

The day also capped the T20 International careers of icons Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli (who came good with a top score of 76 in the final), as also long-time all-purpose handyman Ravindra Jadeja—they chose this high as a fitting occasion to hand over the baton to the next generation in the shortest format of the game. It was also farewell time for head coach Rahul Dravid, who broke his usual stoicism with fist pumps, roars of jubilation and a bout of prancing with the boys. Understandable, for this was only India's second T20 WC triumph after their dramatic win in the inaugural 2007 edition. Also, its first ICC World Cup title in a full 13 years—the wait had been getting unbearably long since the 2011 ODI cup, seeing as how these were the prime years of the Kohli-Sharma duo.



Mission Accomplished Team India with the T20 World Cup at Bridgetown, Barbados, June 29, 2024

AFP

On paper, the win was not a fluke. India are always seen as contenders; they'd also won all their five bilateral T20I series in 2024—even if four were against Afghanistan, Zimbabwe, Sri Lanka and Bangladesh, with only South Africa posing a threat. In fact, India had lost only two T20 matches in the entire year. But with the World Cup in their trophy cabinet, India actually redefined what domination looked like in T20s—that 92.31 per cent win rate won its own legit bragging rights. Statistically, that domination was writ large in an aggressive batting philosophy—a boundary scored every 4.68 balls through 2024, with seven centuries, and the 200-run mark breached nine times—an unprecedented feat in men's T20s. With the ball, too, India were relentless, accurate, disciplined—bowling out opponents in 10 of their 26 matches, and averaging 8.39 wickets per innings.

The sweetness also shone in contrast to the sour notes in other formats in 2024. Yes, there was a masterly 4-1 Test series win over England and a composed 2-0 sweep of Bangladesh later. Yet these were juxtaposed with glaring setbacks, including a surprising ODI series defeat to Sri Lanka in August and an unprecedented 3-0 Test series loss to New Zealand on home soil. It was thus a year of contradictions—periods of unbridled excellence tempered by a frustrating fallibility. Consistency—that's a worthy goal for Team India in 2025. ■